WEEK 6 · LECTURE L2 · UNIT II

Why People Use HR Technology: From TAM to UTAUT

The beliefs and conditions that decide whether a good system is used, why a stack of good tools becomes a bad system, and how champions spread use.

R K Singh · Senior Professor, Department of Commerce · Delhi School of Economics, University of Delhi

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AFTER THIS LECTURE YOU SHOULD BE ABLE TO

What this lecture prepares you for

1. Trace the lineage TAM, TAM2, TAM3, UTAUT and UTAUT2, and diagnose which construct fails.
2. Explain point solutions, data silos and APIs, and why a fragmented stack depresses use.
3. Apply van Dijk’s successive access model and Granovetter’s weak ties to champions networks.
4. Apply systems theory, human capital and the HR scorecard, and adapt rollouts to culture.

ONE SOURCE

The same theories as the in class lecture and the course hub, without the simulation data used in class. Course outcome: CLO 2.

COMMIT BEFORE THEORY

Commit to an answer first

A company rolls out an excellent self service app. Staff say it is useful and easy, yet branch staff barely use it. Which explanation fits UTAUT best?

A

They do not really find it useful

B

Facilitating conditions are missing: devices, data or help at the point of use

C

Their managers are too strict

D

The app needs more features

EXAM LENS

The answer is B. In UTAUT, facilitating conditions act directly on use.

DAVIS (1989)

The Technology Acceptance Model

Perceived usefulness

It improves my job performance.

Perceived ease of use

It is free of effort; ease also raises usefulness.

Intention, then use

The two beliefs shape intention to use, which shapes actual use.

EXAM LENS

Simple and powerful, but silent on social pressure and on the conditions of use.

THEORY IN DEPTH · VENKATESH AND DAVIS (2000); VENKATESH AND BALA (2008)

TAM2 and TAM3: what drives usefulness and ease

The core idea

TAM2 and TAM3 explain where the two TAM beliefs come from, not just their effect.

How it works

TAM2: social influence (subjective norm, voluntariness, image) and cognitive factors (job relevance, output quality, result demonstrability) shape usefulness. TAM3: computer self efficacy, anxiety, playfulness, enjoyment and objective usability shape ease.

Limits and critique

The models grow long and specific, and still explain intention better than actual use.

IN PRACTICE

Show an employee a result they care about, such as leave approved in minutes, to build perceived usefulness. Usefulness and ease are not fixed traits: training, peers and design move them.

EXAM LENS

Trace the lineage: TAM (1989), TAM2, TAM3, UTAUT. Showing the evolution demonstrates depth.

VENKATESH, MORRIS, DAVIS AND DAVIS (2003)

UTAUT: one model from eight

Construct	Question	Mattered more for	Typical HR failure
Performance expectancy	Will it help me do my job?	Younger men	The tool solves HR’s problem, not the employee’s
Effort expectancy	Is it easy to use?	Women, older workers, the less experienced	Desktop style forms on a small phone
Social influence	Do people who matter expect me to use it?	Mandatory settings, early use	Supervisors still accept paper
Facilitating conditions	Do I have the device, data and support?	Older, experienced workers	No smartphone, no data, no help in my language

EXAM LENS

Performance expectancy, effort expectancy and social influence shape intention; facilitating conditions act directly on use. Moderators: gender, age, experience, voluntariness. Diagnose which construct fails before choosing a fix; retraining fixes none of these alone.

For apps on employees' own phones

Limits

Predicts intention better than use; moderators rarely tested well later; built in organizational, often voluntary settings.

UTAUT2 adds

Hedonic motivation (is it enjoyable?), price value (is it worth the cost, such as mobile data?) and habit (is it already routine?).

A typical pattern in adoption data

Use often jumps between low and moderate digital literacy; laptop users show near universal use, feature phone users almost none; completing a training module makes little difference when the barrier is access.

EXAM LENS

For apps on employees' own phones, data cost and habit matter as much as usefulness. Training addresses effort expectancy at best; it cannot supply a device.

INTEGRATION AND ADOPTION

Why silos depress use

Point solutions

Each tool solves one problem well; employees juggle logins and repeat data. With n systems, up to n(n − 1) ÷ 2 links: 120 for 16.

Data silos

Data locked in one system that others cannot read, so people rekey it and stop trusting any system. Private spreadsheets are where silos meet, by hand.

APIs in plain terms

Agreed doors, like a counter window with a fixed form, through which systems pass data automatically.

EXAM LENS

In UTAUT terms, a fragmented stack lowers effort expectancy and weakens facilitating conditions. Compare point to point links with a hub around a system of record.

THEORY IN DEPTH · VAN DIJK (2005; 2020)

Access comes in four successive stages

The core idea

Digital access is not a yes or no switch but four stages, each needing the one before.

How it works

Motivation, then material access, then skills, then usage. Fixing one barrier shifts the inequality to the next; access without skills can widen inequality.

Limits and critique

The stages overlap in real life, and motivation can follow skill rather than precede it.

IN PRACTICE

Feature phone users fail at material access; many smartphone users fail at skills. Each needs a different remedy.

EXAM LENS

Link to the three level divide (Week 2): van Dijk adds motivation as the first stage.

THEORY IN DEPTH · GRANOVETTER (1973)

New ideas travel through weak ties

The core idea

Weak ties, such as acquaintances in other groups, carry new information farther than close friends do.

How it works

Close friends know what you know; bridges between groups bring in the new.

Limits and critique

Strong ties matter more for trust and for adopting risky changes.

IN PRACTICE

A roving champion who visits several sites spreads awareness; a trusted co worker at the same site drives actual use.

EXAM LENS

Use weak ties for awareness and strong ties for adoption.

CHAMPIONS NETWORKS

Social influence by design

1 · Recruit

Respected peers in every team, not only the technically savvy; at frontline sites, where adoption is lowest.

2 · Equip

Train them first; give them a direct line to the project team.

3 · Use

They show, help and report problems back.

4 · Recognize

Give them time and visible credit.

EXAM LENS

Champions often cluster among laptop users and are scarce among smartphone only staff, exactly where they are needed. Champions turn social influence and facilitating conditions from accidents into design.

Three wider lenses from the teaching note

Open systems (von Bertalanffy, 1968)

Organizations take inputs, transform them and produce outputs; parts are interdependent; feedback loops regulate behavior; different paths can reach the same end. HR functions are subsystems, so isolated fixes cascade. Joint optimization (Trist and Bamforth) applies.

Human capital and the HR scorecard

Skills are assets that need investment, depreciate and earn returns (Schultz, 1961; Becker, 1964); firms fund specific training more readily than general. The HR scorecard (Becker, Huselid and Ulrich, 2001): financial, customer, internal process, learning and growth.

Culture (Hofstede et al., 2010)

India: power distance 77, individualism 48, masculinity 56, uncertainty avoidance 40, long term orientation 51, indulgence 26. Visible senior sponsorship, approvals that respect hierarchy, team features, practical demonstrations; localization is more than translation.

EXERCISE

Diagnose why a good tool failed

Step	Question to answer
1 · Choose	Pick one under used tool: self service app, pulse survey or wellbeing app
2 · Locate	Which UTAUT construct fails: performance, effort, social influence or facilitating conditions?
3 · Evidence	What data would show it: device access, literacy, manager behavior?
4 · Fix	Propose one change targeting that construct, not generic retraining

EXAM LENS

If your fix would work equally well for every construct, it does not diagnose anything.

APPLY

An attendance app that drivers ignore

Teaching case (Course framing)

A Delhi bus operator asks 5,000 drivers and conductors to mark attendance and request leave on a new app. Drivers say it would save them trips to the depot office. After two months, 18% use it. Many have low end phones with limited data; the app is in English and needs typing.

Work it through

1. Which UTAUT construct is strong here, and which are weak?
2. Why does high intention not lead to use?
3. Which UTAUT2 addition matters for drivers?
4. Design a champions network for depots.

COMMON CONFUSIONS

Tempting readings, and better ones

A tempting reading	A better reading
If people say it is useful, they will use it	Facilitating conditions act directly on use; intention without means does not become use
UTAUT predicts actual use well	It predicts intention best; measure conditions too
Champions should be the most technical staff	Pick for respect and reach, at the sites with lowest use
Training is the fix for low adoption	Training touches effort expectancy at best; it cannot supply a device or data

COMPARE AND EVALUATE

Lenses on why people use HR technology

Lens	Use it to	Watch out for
TAM (1989)	Name the two core beliefs	Ignores social pressure and conditions
TAM2; TAM3	Find levers for usefulness and ease	Long, and intention focused
UTAUT (2003)	Diagnose by construct	Predicts intention better than use
UTAUT2 (2012)	Add price, habit, enjoyment	Consumer origins
van Dijk	Locate the access stage	Stages overlap
Granovetter (1973)	Design champions networks	Strong ties drive risky adoption

PRACTICE FOR THE END TERM EXAMINATION

Questions to rehearse (1 of 2)

Using TAM and UTAUT, explain why a Bengaluru retailer’s new HR app is used by most head office staff but few store staff, and propose three interventions, each tied to a construct. Note one limit of UTAUT. **20 marks**

A strong answer: defines the TAM beliefs and four UTAUT constructs; locates the gap in facilitating conditions and effort expectancy; ties each intervention to a construct; notes that intention predicts better than use.

“Training is the default response to low adoption, and usually the wrong one.” Critically evaluate using UTAUT and van Dijk’s access model. **20 marks**

A strong answer: diagnoses by construct and access stage; shows why training addresses only some barriers; proposes construct specific remedies.

PRACTICE FOR THE END TERM EXAMINATION

Questions to rehearse (2 of 2)

Explain why integration is the hidden cost of HR technology, and evaluate approaches to reducing it. **20 marks**

A strong answer: uses the n(n – 1) ÷ 2 arithmetic; explains silos and APIs; compares point to point with a hub around a system of record; links to effort expectancy.

How should champions networks be designed, according to Granovetter? **10 marks**

A strong answer: distinguishes weak and strong ties and assigns each a role.

CARRY THESE INTO THE EXAMINATION

Four things to remember

1. **Diagnose which construct fails before choosing a fix.**
   Usefulness, ease, social influence or conditions.

2. **Intention without means does not become use.**
   Facilitating conditions act directly on use.

3. **Every extra system multiplies the connections that must work.**
   Silos depress use.

4. **Champions must sit where adoption is lowest.**
   Weak ties for awareness, strong ties for use.

SET READINGS · FROM THE LESSON PLAN

Read for this lecture

- Venkatesh, V., Morris, M. G., Davis, G. B., & Davis, F. D. (2003). User acceptance of information technology. *MIS Quarterly, 27*(3), 425 to 478.
- Manuti, A., & de Palma, P. D. (2018), Chapters 4 and 5.

NOTE

The other works named in this lecture are theory sources for reference, not set readings.

THEORY SOURCES · FOR REFERENCE

Sources for this lecture

- Becker, B. E., Huselid, M. A., & Ulrich, D. (2001). *The HR scorecard*. Harvard Business School Press.
- Becker, G. S. (1964). *Human capital*. Columbia University Press.
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- Granovetter, M. S. (1973). The strength of weak ties. *American Journal of Sociology, 78*(6), 1360 to 1380. https://doi.org/10.1086/225469
- Hofstede, G., Hofstede, G. J., & Minkov, M. (2010). *Cultures and organizations* (3rd ed.). McGraw Hill.
- Schultz, T. W. (1961). Investment in human capital. *American Economic Review, 51*(1), 1 to 17.
- van Dijk, J. A. G. M. (2005). *The deepening divide*. Sage; (2020). *The digital divide*. Polity.

Sources for this lecture (continued)

- Venkatesh, V., & Bala, H. (2008). Technology acceptance model 3 and a research agenda on interventions. *Decision Sciences, 39*(2), 273 to 315. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1540-5915.2008.00192.x
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- von Bertalanffy, L. (1968). *General system theory*. George Braziller.